Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make a pretty picture, **orange** often appears when we want to **warm** something, **bring it to life** or simply **try** something. **The hand reaches for it before the brain manages to call a meeting**. Sometimes we know exactly **why**, other times not at all. **Both are fine**.

What may be hiding behind an orange stroke

The same orange line on paper can mean **something completely different every time** – depending on what is going on in us at the moment. Sometimes it is **joy**, sometimes **restlessness**, sometimes the pure taste of the colour. That is why there is **no point** in reading a painting like a test with **a single correct answer**.

Joy and playfulness.

Spirals, circles, spilled blotches, strokes that go outwards. The paper is full of movement and there is no hurry anywhere.

The wish to create and try things.

Orange next to many other colours, strokes that run off in all directions. Like when ten ideas hit you at once.

Warmth and closeness.

Soft warm areas around the centre, sometimes around something or someone. A colour that snuggles.

Body and sensuality.

Rounded shapes, waves, areas in the lower part of the paper. The tradition I write about below links orange with the lower part of the body and with pleasure.

The need to be seen.

A sharp, firm stroke near the edge, often in a prominent place. Like a hand raised in a crowd.

Autumn and farewell.

Golden and brownish orange, leaves, falling. Something beautiful that is already leaving, or that you fear will leave.

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Orange in a painting. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, **it can** – but **it does not have to**. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Orange can then give form to joy, to ideas, to a longing for warmth and company, but also to autumn wistfulness or a feeling that you have to be cheerful all the time.

Equally it can simply be **a pretty colour** that you happened to have to hand that day. **Meaning** comes only in connection with **your experience**. **The colour itself does not know what happened to you**. You do – or you will work it out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters is not a single patch of colour but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of orange alone is **not enough for a verdict** on whether it is joy or the need to be cheerful. Perhaps you were in a good mood. Perhaps you wanted to warm up a cold sheet of paper. And perhaps you simply enjoyed that orange so much that grey had no chance that day.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

An orange painting and an orange jumper may ask two completely different things of you. On the **canvas** you give **space to experience**. In clothing you may feel that you are visible and that cheerfulness is expected of you. That is why a large orange area in a painting can attract you while the thought of walking out among people in an orange coat frightens you.

On canvas you can give it enormous space and you do not have to accept at the same time the idea of how you yourself will look in it. **Canvas can be a safe place** where you allow expression in your own way.

Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes only to paint it. Sometimes you enjoy a pumpkin on the table and would not take an orange jumper even as a tombola prize. That is not contradictory.

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When orange takes over the space

First let it come. Perhaps you reach for orange and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas without any duty to explain whether it is joy, longing, anger or a memory of grandmother's apricots. You can paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you when you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more space.

Three things worth noticing

QUANTITY

A small flame, or the whole summer?

A tiny orange trace can be the centre of the whole painting for you. A large area can feel full, free and warming, or it can start to be too insistent. A large orange area is not proof of great joy, and a small trace does not mean you cannot enjoy life.

SATURATION

Saturated, or gentle?

Pure orange can have the look of a freshly cut orange. With white it turns into a gentler apricot. With ochre or brown it approaches clay, leaves or fired ceramics. If after adding white you are flooded with relief, it is exactly that change that is interesting. Perhaps today a less insistent expression suits you. You do not have to make a conclusion about your whole personality out of it.

THICKNESS

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and leave a mark in. Thin paint flows and runs and may surprise you with a direction you had not planned. Sometimes you enjoy the substance and resistance, at other times the chance to let go of control and watch what happens. It is not a test of courage. A careful, thin stroke can be exactly your language for today.

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What to take from the picture

It is not about how the orange stroke looks. More important is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life right now. Two almost identical paintings can have a completely different story. One was made at a celebration, the other after a week when you had to be cheerful all the time. That is why you will not find a **dictionary** here, but **questions**. **Life will not fit into one colour chart anyway**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps after a while you will notice that you kept returning to orange in a period when you were missing **closeness**, **lightness** or the wish to want something for yourself. Perhaps you will connect it with a completely **different experience**. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy a painting can serve as a trace of **your own experience** and a chance to look back.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at a painting and it tells you nothing at all. And a week, a month or a year later it suddenly comes: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in me then.” That is fine. **The painting is not going anywhere**. You **do not have to** squeeze **an answer** out of it with a still-wet brush.

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Joy, nervousness, the senses and autumn sadness all belong to you, and orange can **carry all of it**.

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